



Q What is my role as the birth partner?

Studies show that women who are the least anxious during labor are most likely to have the shortest, easiest, and most positive birthing experience. Birth partners can play a key role in helping mom-to-be to remain as calm as possible, through practical help and keeping her emotionally supported during labor, and by staying calm themselves and hiding any anxiety.

How does staying calm help my partner's labor?

As your partner's contractions intensify, her brain releases endorphins, natural chemicals that boost her pain threshold and help her to deal with labor. Conversely, if your partner feels anxious, her body releases adrenaline, signaling to the brain that danger is present. The body then decides this is not a good moment to give birth and inhibits the release of endorphins and oxytocin, the hormone that controls contractions, which can in turn stall her labor.

What are the best ways to help my partner?

There are plenty of ways to keep your partner comfortable and motivated (see box, below), but two of the most important

things, from which all other practical tips stem, are to be informed about labor, and to know her preferences for labor, birth, and after the delivery. Reading up on labor (how it progresses and how your partner may feel at different points), and attending childbirth classes with your partner toward the end of pregnancy will help you to be prepared on the day. If possible beforehand, talk through your partner's birth plan with her so you can advocate for her when she is too tired or preoccupied to ask or answer questions. How she will feel once in labor is an unknown for you both, so be ready to be flexible and react to her responses on the day, whether she wants to be touched and held, or she retreats into her own space, with you close by.

THE BIRTH PARTNER'S ROLE

A continuous source of care from start to finish, a birth partner plays an active role in creating a sense of calm and helps to keep the mom-to-be motivated. Here are some practical ways you can help things go smoothly.



The buildup

- » Take a tour of the hospital where your partner will give birth during her third trimester to learn what to expect from the facility and the staff.
- » If you'll be going to a birthing center, find out if they offer bathtubs during labor or birthing pools for delivery, if those are your partner's wishes.
- » Provide snacks, meals, and drinks for your partner (it's important that she stays hydrated throughout labor).
- » Create the atmosphere your partner would like; for example, lower the lighting if she wants, play music, or light candles.
- » Give your partner a relaxing back massage or run her a warm bath if she wants.



On the move

- » Don't go over the alcohol limit in late pregnancy so you can drive safely.
- » Be informed about hospital parking (where this is and do you need change).
- » Have a taxi company number ready if you don't drive.
- » Know where your partner's birth plan and hospital bag are.
- » Be informed about child-care arrangements for older children and implement them when the time comes.
- » If a doctor or ambulance is coming to you, make sure the house number is clearly visible.
- » Don't cut it close—leave for the hospital in plenty of time.



During labor

- » Breathe with your partner during contractions.
- » Support her in upright positions.
- » Ask questions if she is offered an intervention so she can make an informed decision: what are pros and cons?
- » Make your partner's needs and wishes heard when she is tired or emotional.
- » Articulate the medical team's instructions when your partner is too distracted to hear them, and respect their professional opinion.
- » Read her nonverbal signals: has she had enough talking/stroking/massaging?
- » Reassure, support, and encourage her.
- » Sponge her face, and offer sips of water.
- » Stay nourished and hydrated yourself.